

Three Days in Okinawa

Okinawa is made up of over 100 islands spread out over a considerable distance, so if you plan on seeing more than just the main island, you will need at least three or four days. However, many Japanese pop down to the main island simply for a long weekend by the beach.

DAY ONE Spend a day wandering the archipelago's capital, **Naha**. Go shopping (and eat) at the enormous **Makishi Market** and poke among the capital's shops for Ryukyuan lacquerware and glassware.

DAY TWO Head to the north of **Okinawa Honto** to enjoy the beaches or visit the **Ocean Expo Park**, which has a gigantic aquarium and is home to the **Native Okinawan Village**, featuring 20 houses from different eras. Then take a diving trip out to some of Japan's best **coral reefs**, or chill out at a beachside bar and try local delicacies like *goya chanpuru* and *umibudo* (caviar-like seaweed).

DAY THREE Take a short flight to the southernmost island of **Iriomote** and go hiking through the jungle in search of the super-rare Iriomote wild cat (fewer than 100 are thought to remain).

Essentials

GETTING THERE

There are regular flights from mainland Japan to Naha's **airport**, which also receives some international flights. There are decent **ferry** and **air** networks between the islands.

WHERE TO STAY

APA Hotel Naha (inexpensive) is a large, business-oriented hotel with reasonably priced rooms. www.apahotel.com

Okinawa Nahana Hotel (moderate) has large, modern rooms and a spa; it's also handily within walking distance of the market. www.ishinhotels.com/okinawanahana/en

Busena Terrace (expensive) is Okinawa's most lavish resort hotel, complete with underwater viewing tower. www.terrace.co.jp

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.pref.okinawa.jp/english/tourism

Right The vast Makishi Market in the center of Naha sells all kinds of foods, including some unique to Okinawa

Below Many of Okinawa's beautiful beaches have coral reefs and are great places for snorkeling

